System Administrator vs Network Administrator: What's the Difference?

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Video: Becoming a Network Systems Administrator

Are you interested in a career as a Network Systems Administrator but are not sure how to start preparing for it? We have you covered!

KEY TAKEAWAYS:

- Because system administrators are in charge of coordinating activities from multiple users, they need to ensure that all system applications are compatible with each part of the computing network.
- Determining which software to use in conjunction with the computer hardware is an important part of a system administrator's position.
- While some smaller organizations combine the responsibilities of both positions into one role, large computing systems often require specialized support for each type of IT administration.

Systems administrators and network administrators are both important roles within the IT department. While some smaller organizations combine the responsibilities of both positions into one role, large computing systems often require specialized support for each type of IT administration. For people interested in IT management, both system administrator and network administrator roles can be part of a rewarding career path. Before applying for jobs, research the similarities and differences between these roles so you can select the right position for you.

In this article, we compare and contrast the experience, duties and requirements for systems administrators and network administrators.

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INSIGHTS FROM INDEED

Network administrator Hiring Insights

Average pay

$84,444 / year

Low $26,000 **High** $176,000

Job seekers

23,852

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628

+628 with open roles this month

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What is a systems administrator?

A systems administrator is in charge of overseeing the functionality of computer systems. They focus on ensuring that all software and hardware components work properly to accomplish system objectives. Systems administrators deal with issues related to physical computer servers, other hardware and software infrastructure. They provide assistance for users that need to access IT databases and other system functions. Typical duties for a system administrator include:

- **Installing computer servers:** Systems administrators order the appropriate server hardware and set up the physical environment for the server. They set up the server equipment, install operating systems and run tests to confirm functionality.
- **Updating computer drivers and software systems:** Determining which software to use in conjunction with the computer hardware is an important part of a system administrator's position. They install software and schedule updates to patch bugs, add features and improve the systems interface.
- **Diagnosing server issues:** IT departments rely on systems administrators to run diagnostic tests and determine the cause of system failures or delays. System administrators follow a logical troubleshooting process to find the digital or physical source of a server problem.
- **Responding to tickets from users:** System users submit help tickets to report bugs or issues within the server environment. Systems administrators read each ticket and help users fix their problem or access the correct information.
- **Backing up data:** Creating and protecting copies of critical system data is one of the main roles of a system administrator. They prepare a data backup schedule to create multiple copies of system code in case someone needs to revert to a previous version of the computer system.
- **Determining recovery procedures:** System administrators are responsible for establishing the process for recovering lost data and reconfiguring a system after a crash. They write instructions that explain how to reliably recover information in different scenarios.

- **Identifying application compatibility:** Because system administrators are in charge of coordinating activities from multiple users, they need to ensure that all system applications are compatible with each part of the computing network.
- **Setting up user accounts:** System administrators create new user accounts, assign them to appropriate permissions, set passwords and perform other manual changes for system users. They can access user accounts to remotely resolve issues for individual users or all users within a specific server category.
- **Documenting system changes:** Documentation is a critical aspect of running a successful system. System administrators keep a record of all key server activities, changes and outages to guide future system development.

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What is a network administrator?

Network administrators are IT professionals responsible for maintaining network connectivity. They focus on setting up network equipment and ensuring that their network infrastructure can support user activities. Network administrators monitor overall activity and demands on the network to identify vulnerabilities or strange activity. They're in charge of ensuring that IT systems don't lose connectivity and determining the cause of connection issues. A network administrator's responsibilities include:

- **Researching and selecting network hardware:** Network administrators are responsible for choosing and ordering the right networking equipment to meet their clients' needs. They select the right cables, routes and switches to support networks of different sizes and capabilities.
- **Installing networking equipment:** Network administrators also physically install networking equipment to properly project a network signal. They install and secure cables, adjust plug connections and set up devices to boost and stabilize their connection.
- **Configuring network-enabled devices:** Setting up devices so they can connect to a network and its related server is a core task for network administrators. They help clients set up their computers, phones and software systems to automatically access information through a specific network channel.
- **Monitoring network activity:** Observing user activity and network processing loads helps network administrators identify potential problems, prevent users from overloading the system and upholding security standards. System administrators identify areas of high network activity and make adjustments to limit the impact on network speed or stability.
- **Troubleshooting network connectivity problems:** If a client has a problem connecting to their network, network administrators determine the cause of the issue. They run network connectivity tests, assess upload and download speeds and remotely access client devices to identify user-end network issues.
- **Setting up firewalls:** Network administrators are in charge of keeping their networks secure using firewalls and other network security tools. They refine the firewall settings to give permissions to the correct users and prevent any unauthorized access of information.
- **Respond to outage reports:** When network outages impact and entire system, network administrators inspect the hardware and software systems to determine the cause of the outage and restore connection for all users.

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What are the similarities between system administrators and network administrators?

System administrators and network administrators are both IT professionals that develop, support and maintain information technology infrastructure. Although they focus on different aspects of running a computing system, both system administrators and network administrators work to facilitate day-to-day operations for a system. They collaborate to provide system users with reliable ways to access information and execute IT operations. Because network issues can impact servers and vice versa, network administrators and system administrators might perform similar troubleshooting duties and tasks when resolving an issue in their area of expertise. Other types of similarities include:

Work environment

Both network administrators and system administrators work in an office environment, primarily using software tools on a computer. They also visit physical sites to install and repair equipment, which requires some basic travel. Network administrators and system administrators both work full-time and may have options for flexible overtime.

Skills

Network administrators and system administrators have similar skills that they use when solving problems and managing their network or server. Because they work so closely together, network administrators and system administrators need to understand one another's technical skills. Some of the primary skills involved in these professions are:

- Networking
- Problem-solving
- Strategic thinking
- Data analysis
- Hardware installation
- Scripting languages
- Device management
- Cloud computing

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Job outlook

As businesses grow their IT capabilities, they generate demand for both network administrators and system administrators. According to the Bureau of Labor Services, network and computer systems administrators can expect a 4% increase in jobs through 2029.

What are the differences between a system administrator vs a network administrator?

Despite their similarities, system administrators and network administrators have distinct roles with many differences. To understand the system and network administrator positions, consider their unique attributes in each of these core aspects of the job:

Scope of work

System administrators and network administrators have different general objectives, with network administrators accomplishing tasks related to network maintenance and system administrators focusing on operating systems, servers and software platforms. Network administrators work with concepts related to network device scripting, routing, IP addresses, network proxies and access points. System administrators specialize in knowledge about system capacities, data virtualization, inventory and analytics.

Salary

Network administrators and system administrators can both earn a comfortable salary, but systems administrators have a slightly higher earning potential. System administrators earn an average salary of $82,591 per year, while network administrators have an average salary of $71,972 per year. Many companies require systems administrators and network administrators to be on-call in case of a system or network problem, which enables them to earn additional income through overtime pay.

Equipment

System administrators and network administrators both access their IT systems by entering code and executing actions on a computer, but they use different kinds of equipment when working with the hardware aspects of their jobs. Network administrators work with network hardware like network gateways, repeaters, ethernet hubs and wireless access points. Typical equipment for system administrators include mainframes, tower servers, disc drives, motherboards, memory cards and power supply cables.

Education

System administrators and network administrators have similar education requirements. Employers typically expect a bachelor's degree in computer science, information technology, software engineering or a related field. You can customize your education to either career path by taking courses that focus on either type of engineering and administration. To become a network administrators, you can take courses in cybersecurity, database administration and programming. Topics that system administrators should study during their undergraduate education include computer virtualization, operating system administration, device maintenance and software development.

To gain advanced skills in either role, you can consider getting a master's in computer science, networking or system administration. This can help you qualify for positions working with expansive and complex computing systems, databases and device networks.

Experience

System administrators and network administrators should be mid-career with several years of experience in IT. To become a system administrators, you can typically gain experience in an IT helpdesk environment or work as a server hardware technician to develop your skills. Network administrators can look for positions as database specialists and IT communications professionals.

Certification

You can find specialty certifications for both system administrators and network administrators. Many IT certifications can be helpful to both career paths, especially because of the overlap between the two positions. Programming certifications are especially relevant to system administrators, while security and cloud services certifications apply well to network administrator roles.

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How to decide between being a system administrator or a network administrator

If you're considering a career path as either a system administrators or a network administrator, follow these steps to determine which one is best for you:

1. Take courses in both subjects

Learn about the duties involved with each positions by taking courses related to both career paths. Once you find a topic that interests you, you can adjust your education plan to focus on that specialty. Consider what you enjoy about each IT subject and determine which role provides the best opportunities for you to work in that area.

2. Work with a smaller IT system

Look for jobs at smaller companies that only have one IT administrator working with both their network and their server systems. This can allow you to gain firsthand experience with both types of responsibilities. Working in a position where you serve multiple roles can help you understand both jobs better and determine which one you would rather pursue.

3. Establish career goals

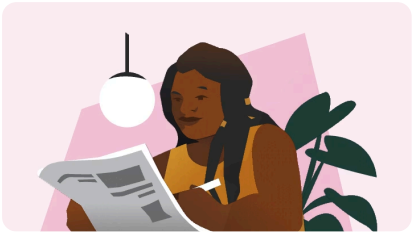
Think about your long-term career goals and what future roles you could qualify for after getting experience as a network administrator or a systems administrators. Network administrators can use their knowledge of IT communications to become IT directors, chief information officers and network architects. System administrators can apply their experience to become system engineers and system architects.

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